

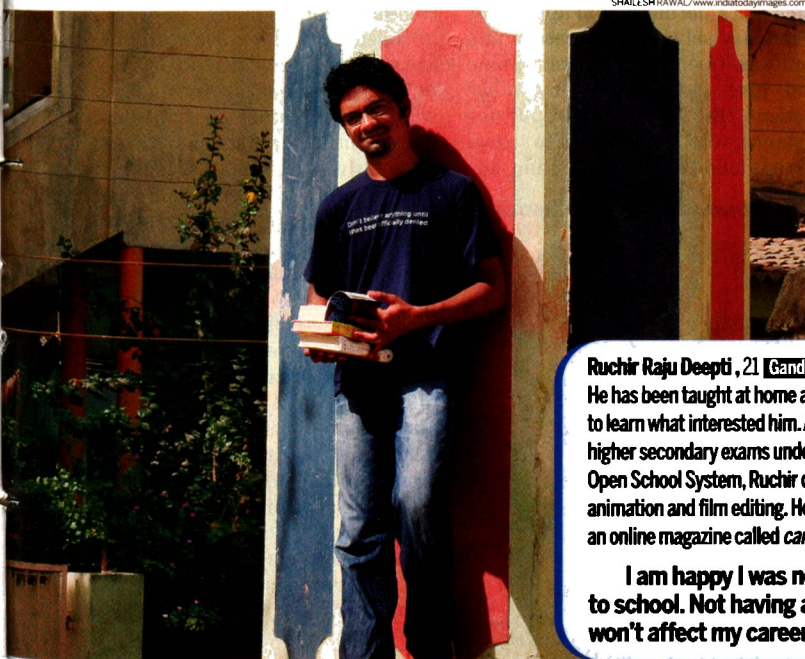


THE SAMSONS WITH THEIR CHILDREN
(LEFT TO RIGHT) SAHYA, NIOM AND RAYN

believe that it is working for their children. Unlike many home schoolers who quit school after a negative experience, the Samsons have consciously decided not to school their children from the beginning. Their older son Rayn, 13, enjoys technology and keeps tooling around with stuff while her younger son Niom, 10, is creative and writes stories. Their daughter is about to get her first book of poems released very soon and has a creative bent of mind. "We are very unhappy with the mainstream but we are passionate about what we do so we have created an alternative system," says Urmila. The mother is clear that her children will never appear for any public exam and nor is she stressed about what they may do in future as she believes that they will do things which are fulfilling.

While many believe that parents like the Samsons are going back to the days when formal schooling did not exist, there may be some pitfalls in this path as well. While home schooling very often helps hone the hidden potential of a child, educationists believe that parents should ensure that the children attain sufficient life skills to earn a livelihood. Says Nitya Ramaswamy, head of child development and academics at Zee Learning, "Parents must teach their children life skills necessary to make a living. Academic competence can be taught at home but for that parents need to be very disciplined themselves."

Most parents who choose to dump the conventional system need to be doubly responsible and present for the children to meet their needs. Arun Ellassery and his wife Kanti both work out of home so that the whole family can be together and do things collectively. Arun, who works for an education company, has no fight against the existing schooling system and he took a decision to



Ruchir Raju Deepti, 21, Gandhinagar

He has been taught at home and has chosen to learn what interested him. After clearing higher secondary exams under the National Open School System, Ruchir did a course in animation and film editing. He is now running an online magazine called *care4nature*.

I am happy I was not sent to school. Not having a degree won't affect my career.